

DIFFERING VOICES Bihar CM Samrat Choudhary and, from top left, Nitish Kumar, Chirag Paswan, Prashant Kishore and Tejashwi Yadav

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BIHAR

THE TONE IS CIVIL, THE DISQUIET IS UNIFORM

The UCC faces a genuine atumbling block in Bihar, as BJP seeks not to upset partners JD(U) and LJP. Muslim alienation could upset electoral equilibrium

By **Amitabh Srivastava**

FIVE DAYS AND OVER A THOUSAND MILES separate two sentences that frame the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) question in Bihar. On September 13, in faraway Mumbai, Union home minister Amit Shah said that, by 2029, the UCC's footprint would cover all 21 states ruled by the National Democratic Alliance (NDA). However, its relatively unproblematic rollout—one state done, three in the process—may not be a clear portent for states like Bihar. On September 18, chief minister Samrat Choudhary gestured at the complication. Upon questioning, he did not contradict Shah, but said, "We will talk to everyone, and then make a decision."

Speaking at an INDIA TODAY group event in Patna, Samrat was responding to a reminder that his coalition partners—Janata Dal (United) and Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas)—had questions over the UCC. His deference owes to arithmetic. The NDA has 202 seats in the 243-member assembly. But the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has only 88, after losing Bankipur; the JD(U) has 85, Chirag Paswan's LJP (RV) 19, HAM and smaller allies make up the rest. That is, the BJP is well short of the majority mark of 122 on its own. Will its allies join in for the UCC ride?

The initial sounds hint at caution, and that flows from demography. Bihar's 2023 caste survey put the Muslim population at 17.7 per cent. In Kishanganj, they form a majority; in Katihar, Araria and Purnia, they are a substantial presence; the community's electoral weight across Seemanchal and parts of north Bihar is considerable. The BJP has no need for it as a source of sustenance—in fact, it thrives by consolidating the others. Its allies do not work out of a similar political logic.

The JD(U), especially, has historically sought to retain an independent social and political identity even while in an alliance with the BJP—nowhere does its playbook 'cancel' the Muslim